

100 Idioms

职场

all in the same boat

处境相同

Everyone on my team has to work late this week, so we're all in the same boat.

burn the midnight oil

熬夜赶工

I burned the midnight oil on the slides, so I can't keep my eyes open in the meeting.

call it a day

收工

We finished the slides at 9 p.m., so we called it a day and went home.

cut corners

偷工减料

The old building cut corners on the walls, so water now leaks into my room.

drop the ball

搞砸了

I dropped the ball and forgot to renew my metro card, so I got stuck at the gate.

get the ball rolling

开个头

We've planned enough; let's get the ball rolling and write the first page today.

go the extra mile

多走一步，加倍用心

The delivery rider went the extra mile and carried my heavy box up to the sixth floor.

in hot water

惹上麻烦

He's in hot water because he sent the report three days after the deadline.

nip something in the bud

及早制止

My manager nipped the rumor in the bud by posting the real numbers in the group chat.

on thin ice

处境危险

He's on thin ice at work; one more mistake and he could lose the job.

show someone the ropes

带新手入门

On my first day, my colleague showed me the ropes; how to book a room and where to get tea.

the ball is in your court

轮到你决定

I sent my resume to the HR manager; now the ball is in her court.

up in the air

悬而未决

The weekend trip is still up in the air; we're waiting for the weather report.

人际沟通

all ears

洗耳恭听

I finished my work early, so I'm all ears; tell me about your interview.

barking up the wrong tree

找错对象, 白费力气

If you think I took your phone, you're barking up the wrong tree; I stayed home all evening.

beat around the bush

拐弯抹角

Stop beating around the bush and tell me why you missed the meeting.

bury the hatchet

和好, 冰释前嫌

After arguing for a week, my roommate and I buried the hatchet over hotpot.

get a taste of your own medicine

自食其果

He always hides my mouse, so he got a taste of his own medicine when I hid his keyboard.

get your wires crossed

搞误会

We got our wires crossed; I thought dinner was Friday, but it was Saturday.

give someone the benefit of the doubt

姑且相信

My coworker said the printer ate her report, and I gave her the benefit of the doubt this time.

hit the nail on the head

一针见血

My mom hit the nail on the head; I stayed up playing games instead of studying.

let the cat out of the bag

说漏嘴

My brother let the cat out of the bag about the surprise cake, and now Mom knows.

make a long story short

长话短说

To make a long story short, I missed the high-speed rail and had to buy another ticket.

on the same page

意见一致

My roommate and I finally got on the same page about the cleaning schedule, so we stopped arguing.

pull someone's leg

开玩笑逗人

My coworker said the elevator is broken, but he was just pulling my leg; it works fine.

put your foot in your mouth

说错话

I put my foot in my mouth when I asked my coworker about the baby; she isn't pregnant.

take a rain check

改天再说

I can't make dinner tonight because of overtime; can I take a rain check?

情绪感受

at the end of your rope

忍无可忍

After waiting thirty minutes for a delivery that never came, I was at the end of my rope.

cold feet

临阵退缩

I planned to quit my job, but I got cold feet before sending the email.

drive someone up the wall

把人逼疯

My neighbor's dog barking at midnight drives me up the wall.

get a grip

冷静点

Get a grip; it's just one bad score, not the end of the world.

get bent out of shape

火大, 气得不行

My roommate gets bent out of shape when I leave my shoes by the door.

get off on the wrong foot

一开始就不顺

We got off on the wrong foot; I spilled coffee on my new colleague on her first day.

in the heat of the moment

一时冲动

I said something rude to my boss in the heat of the moment, and now I regret it.

keep your chin up

别灰心

You failed the test twice, but keep your chin up; the third time is often lucky.

like a fish out of water

格格不入

I felt like a fish out of water at the formal dinner with my girlfriend's colleagues.

on cloud nine

开心极了

When my boss approved my Spring Festival leave, I was on cloud nine.

put someone on the spot

让人下不来台

My boss put me on the spot and asked for the answer right there in the meeting.

throw someone for a loop

让人措手不及

The interviewer asked about my salary plans, and it threw me for a loop.

态度观点

at the drop of a hat

二话不说

My mom comes to help at the drop of a hat; I just send one WeChat message.

cross that bridge when you come to it

到时再说

I don't know what to do if the landlord raises the rent, but I'll cross that bridge when I come to it.

cry over spilled milk

后悔也没用

My phone is broken, and crying over spilled milk won't fix it; I just ordered a new one.

go with the flow

顺其自然

I don't plan my weekends; I just go with the flow and see who is free.

jump the gun

操之过急

He jumped the gun and told everyone the news before the boss approved it.

no-brainer

想都不用想

When the app offered free same-day delivery, choosing it was a no-brainer.

not my cup of tea

不对胃口

Horror movies are not my cup of tea; I watch them with my eyes half closed.

on the fence

犹豫不决

I'm on the fence about the new phone; mine still works, but the camera is old.

play it by ear

随机应变

We haven't booked anything for the trip; we'll play it by ear when we arrive.

put the cart before the horse

本末倒置

I booked the hotel before asking for leave; I put the cart before the horse.

save your breath

别白费口舌

Save your breath; my mom has already decided where we'll go for the holiday.

shoot yourself in the foot

搬起石头砸自己的脚

I told my boss I was free, and he gave me the biggest project; I shot myself in the foot.

silver lining

不幸中的万幸

I failed the driving test, but the silver lining is that my dad and I get more practice rides together.

take it with a grain of salt

半信半疑

He said the salary is very high, but take it with a grain of salt; it's just a rumor.

turn a blind eye

睁一只眼闭一只眼

The teacher turned a blind eye when students checked their phones in class.

生活日常

a night owl

夜猫子

I'm a night owl; I do my best work after 11 p.m.

bring home the bacon

养家糊口

She does live-streaming at night to bring home the bacon for her family.

cost an arm and a leg

贵得离谱

Renting an apartment near the metro costs an arm and a leg, so I moved two stops away.

eyeball it

目测

I had no ruler, so I eyeballed the shelf width before buying it online.

jump on the bandwagon

跟风

Everyone at my office uses the new AI tool, so I jumped on the bandwagon too.

kick the bucket

去世 (口语)

He jokes that he wants to eat hotpot in Chongqing before he kicks the bucket.

kill two birds with one stone

一举两得

I listen to English podcasts on the metro, so I kill two birds with one stone on the way to work.

once in a blue moon

极少发生

I cook at home most days and order takeout once in a blue moon, only when I work late.

out of the blue

突然，毫无预兆

My college classmate called me out of the blue yesterday after five years.

pipe down

安静点

Pipe down, everyone; the teacher is about to start.

spice things up

换换花样

We always eat at home, so let's spice things up and try the new hotpot place.

the best of both worlds

两全其美

Working from home gives me the best of both worlds; no crowded commute and more time with my cat.

under the weather

身体不舒服

I felt under the weather this morning, so I called my boss and worked from home.

压力挑战

between a rock and a hard place

进退两难

I'm between a rock and a hard place; the job pays well, but the office is far away.

bite the bullet

硬着头皮做

My air conditioner broke in July, so I bit the bullet and called the landlord at 11 p.m.

elephant in the room

避而不谈的大问题

Everyone knows the project is late, but nobody mentions it; it's the elephant in the room.

face the music

承担后果

I arrived late again, so I have to face the music and explain to my boss.

go down in flames

彻底失败

The live-streaming sale went down in flames; only three people watched.

hang in there

坚持住

The gym is hard at first, but hang in there; you'll see changes after a month.

off the hook

脱身，不用担责

The meeting was canceled, so I'm off the hook and can go home early.

the last straw

最后一根稻草

The slow elevator was the last straw; I finally moved out of that building.

throw caution to the wind

豁出去，不顾后果

She threw caution to the wind and spent a month's salary on a trip to Yunnan.

throw in the towel

认输放弃

After three failed interviews, she threw in the towel and looked for a job in another city.

when it rains, it pours

祸不单行

My bike chain broke in the morning, and then my phone died; when it rains, it pours.

学习成长

by the skin of your teeth

差一点，侥幸

I caught the last train by the skin of my teeth; the doors closed right behind me.

it's a piece of cake

小菜一碟

Ordering food on WeChat is a piece of cake; even my six-year-old niece can do it.

lose your touch

手生了

I haven't cooked for months, so I've lost my touch; the noodles were too salty.

not ring a bell

没印象

He says we met at a party, but his face doesn't ring a bell.

play devil's advocate

唱反调

Everyone likes the plan, but let me play devil's advocate; what if the app crashes on launch day?

rule of thumb

经验法则

My rule of thumb is to order takeout before 11:30, or I wait forty minutes for lunch.

swallow something hook, line, and sinker

全盘相信

My son said the dog ate his homework, and I almost swallowed it hook, line, and sinker.

wrap your head around something

想明白, 弄懂

It took me a week to wrap my head around the new scheduling app.

形容评价

a blessing in disguise

因祸得福

Losing my old job turned into a blessing in disguise; my new office is ten minutes from home.

a dime a dozen

到处都是, 不稀奇

Coffee shops near my office are a dime a dozen, so I always find a seat at lunch.

a whole new ballgame

全新的局面

After the baby came, weekends became a whole new ballgame; no more lazy mornings.

clear as mud

一团糟, 看不懂

The instructions for the new app were as clear as mud, so I asked my coworker for help.

has seen better days

破旧，今非昔比

My laptop has seen better days; the battery dies in thirty minutes.

miss the boat

错失机会

I waited too long to buy the concert tickets, so I missed the boat; they sold out.

off the chain

太炸了，绝了

The concert last night was off the chain; the whole crowd sang along.

piece of work

难搞的人

The new manager is a real piece of work; she changed the schedule three times today.

play your cards right

把握机会，好好表现

The boss likes your work, so if you play your cards right, you'll get the promotion.

show your true colors

露出真面目

When the project failed, my friend showed his true colors and blamed everything on me.

skeletons in the closet

不可告人的秘密

People say the new manager has skeletons in his closet, but nobody knows what they are.

steal the show

抢尽风头

The little girl danced at the wedding and stole the show.

the whole nine yards

全套，一样不落

For the wedding, she prepared the dresses, the photos, the whole nine yards.

through thick and thin

同甘共苦

We've been roommates for six years, through thick and thin, rent hikes and leaky pipes.